

Keeping something because you think you might need it again someday

8 findings · 12-step checklist · 5 sources · cheatgrid.com

You keep it so you never have to blame yourself later for letting it go. That's different from having a plan for it, and the regret you're guarding against fades fast.

THE GOAL

You're deciding this one today, instead of leaving it frozen. **Name the actual day you'd use it**, and if you can't name one, it leaves the house.

CHECKLIST

You're holding the item, standing over the drawer, shelf or closet, trying to decide whether to keep it or let it go.

- ☐ Say the actual last time you used it, a season or an event you can name, not just "a while."
- ☐ Pick your own cutoff for how long counts as unused, some stretch you're comfortable naming, and check if the last use clears it.
- ☐ If what's keeping it is a specific date or task you can name, that counts. A vague feeling that you might need it someday doesn't.
- ☐ If it doesn't clear your cutoff, **put it in a bag marked to leave the house**, not back in the drawer "for now."
- ☐ If a pang of regret comes up, say to yourself: "this will feel smaller in a week than it does now," and keep moving.
- ☐ Write the item's name and today's date on a slip of paper and drop it into the bag with it.
- ☐ Carry the bag to wherever it leaves from today: the car, the door, the donation box, not a shelf to sort "later."
- ☐ If it clears your cutoff, or you have a real date for it, **name that occasion out loud**: a day, a trip, a task.
- ☐ Write that occasion down somewhere you'll see again: a calendar entry, or a note tucked with the item.
- ☐ Put it where that occasion will actually meet it, like by the door or with the outfit, not back in the same spot.
- ☐ Set a date to check on it, tied to the occasion you named: if that date passes unused, that's a new decision, not this one.
- ☐ If you're telling yourself you should already be done, close this one out and move to just the next item.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** You're not keeping this because you have a plan for it. You're keeping it so **you never have to blame yourself later** for having let it go.
- 2** If you let this go and miss it, the bad feeling won't last nearly as long as it feels.
- 3** **Name the actual day you'll use it** instead of "someday," or it stays frozen in the drawer for years.

What's actually driving this

KNOW

You're not keeping this because you have a plan for it. You're keeping it so **you never have to blame yourself later** for having let it go.

The urge to keep it has a name: anticipated regret, bracing against a future "I told you so" aimed at yourself. [Source 1](#)

WATCH

Notice when something starts to feel "too special" to actually use. That feeling usually means you've been avoiding it.

The same pattern held for a notebook, a bottle of wine, and a saved TV episode alike. [Source 2](#)

Why the fear is bigger than what's likely

KNOW

If you let this go and miss it, the bad feeling won't last nearly as long as it feels.

People reliably overestimate how long a bad feeling will last, a well-documented durability bias. [Source 3](#)

DON'T

Don't assume you'd struggle for long if this situation came up and you didn't have it. People bounce back from setbacks like that faster than they expect.

People consistently **underestimate how fast** they'll personally recover from a hard event. [Source 3](#)

What's normal, and what isn't about self-control

KNOW

In one large survey of UK wardrobes, about a quarter of the clothes people owned hadn't been worn in over a year. Unused items sitting around is simply normal.

The same survey found people also keep pairs of socks and underwear they rarely touch. [Source 4](#)

KNOW

The people who found decluttering hardest simply had less time, support and control than everyone else.

Look for a chunk of set-aside time or an extra pair of hands before blaming your own discipline. [Source 5](#)

What changes what actually happens

WATCH

How much you dread sorting through stuff says little: people who dreaded it most still ended up glad afterward.

All three groups, even the most reluctant, felt more positive after finishing than they did before they started. [Source 5](#)

DO

Name the actual day you'll use it instead of "someday," or it stays frozen in the drawer for years.

This kind of upfront plan is what stopped people from letting an item drift into feeling too special to use. [Source 2](#)

Sources

1. <https://news.unm.edu/news/embrace-a-tidier-today-anderson-professor-provides-insight-into-decluttering-research>
2. <https://metropolitandigital.com/the-conversation/9205-psychological-specialness-spirals-can-make-ordinary-items-feel-like-treasures---and-may-explain-how-clutter-accumulates>
3. <https://www.happierlivesinstitute.org/report/affective-forecasting/>
4. <https://www.wrap.ngo/media-centre/press-releases/nations-wardrobes-hold-16-billion-items-unworn-clothes-people-open-new>
5. https://www.challengingdisorganization.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/08/Short-Summary-of-Roster-and-Ferrari-2022-Article_Having-Less_-JOCA-Rev.pdf

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Clutter and keeping things at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)